

From: motherofpekes@icloud.com 
Subject: Welfare Clarification Request: Bitless Bridles in Dressage
Date: 10 April 2026 at 6:59 am
To: mail@rspcansw.org.au



Dear RSPCA Campaigns Team,

I was referred to you following a phone enquiry with RSPCA NSW earlier today.

I am currently engaging with Equestrian Australia and Dressage NSW regarding the inclusion of bitless bridles in dressage competition. At present, the use of a bit remains mandatory in affiliated dressage tests, regardless of the individual horse's response to that equipment.

Bitless bridles are already permitted in other equestrian disciplines, including show jumping, where horses are ridden at speed over complex courses. This suggests that their use can be compatible with effective control and safety.

My aim is not to advocate against bits, but to support the inclusion of bitless options as a welfare-aligned alternative for horses who show discomfort, stress, or conflict behaviours associated with bitted bridles.

This is not a novel or untested proposal. Other national federations, including the Dutch federation (KNHS), already permit bitless bridles in dressage at certain levels. More broadly, there is increasing international discussion around equipment choice and welfare in ridden horses.

For context, I have attached a brief one-page summary of the welfare considerations.

In this context, I would be grateful for clarification on the following:

- Whether the use of bitless bridles is considered consistent with RSPCA NSW's animal welfare principles
- Whether providing riders with the option to choose bitless equipment (where safe and appropriate) would be viewed as a positive welfare development
- Whether I may accurately state that this approach aligns with RSPCA welfare considerations when engaging with governing bodies

I am not requesting that RSPCA NSW take on this issue as a campaign, but simply seeking guidance on how this sits within established welfare frameworks.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Kind regards,
Paula Lasersohn

Author: *The Faulty Premise: Why Modern Dressage Cannot Reconcile Performance with Welfare — and What Must Change*
Dressage for the Future
Canberra, Australia

**Brief Bitless Bridles and Welfare
Considerations in Dressage.pdf**

